WORK WITH AI

Critical Thinking

Here's the big takeaway from the first part of this course. And in the spirit of AI, let's write it as a math equation.

THE EQUATION

Learn More

=

More Knowledge

=

Better Questions & Better Results

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Be Smarter Than the Tool

That equation leaves out one skill: the one that raises every line of it. It matters enough that we could have called this lesson **How to Take Your AI Use from a B to an A+**.

It's called **critical thinking**. And it will help you far beyond AI: in school, in work, in almost every part of your life.

Our dad told us there's almost a direct line between this skill and the people who get the most out of AI. That's why AI experts use the term constantly. But what does it actually mean? The answer fits in one more equation.

ONE MORE EQUATION

Critical + Thinking = **A+** Your AI use at its best.

CRITICAL

Don't take things at face value. Not everything is false, but the things that are don't announce themselves.

THINKING

AI gives you answers, but you must own the thinking. The moment you stop, you're not using the tool anymore. You're obeying it.

Put the words together and you have a process: actively analyzing, questioning, and evaluating information, regardless of where it comes from, before deciding what to believe or do.

It isn't "don't trust anything," either. It's the habit of asking what would have to be true for a claim to hold up.

Here's a real example. In 2015, headlines around the world announced a delicious discovery: a new study showed that eating chocolate helps you lose weight. "Slim by Chocolate!" ran one front page. Your reaction can go two directions.

REACTION 1

"Wow. I can eat all the chocolate I want and still lose ten pounds!"

REACTION 2

"Wait a second. That sounds too good to be true. What's behind this study?"

The second reaction is critical thinking, and anyone who ran that check found quite a story. The study was real, but it was flimsy on purpose: 15 participants, with 18 different things measured, so pure chance guaranteed that something would look like a result. The "research institute" behind it was just a website. The author was a journalist who designed the whole thing to prove a point: that a bad study with a great headline would fly around the world before anyone checked. It did.

That's a big part of critical thinking: the ability to read between the lines, especially when the claim is something you'd love to believe.

You just practiced spotting weak reasoning in any claim. These five habits are how you run that instinct on AI output, every time, before you trust it.

CRITICAL THINKING AND AI

There are five habits you can build to sharpen your critical thinking with AI.

The 5 Habits

01 ❓ QUESTION THE OUTPUT

Your first instinct: is this actually right?

Don't take the answer at face value. Ask what would have to be true for it to hold up.

02 🙄 KNOW YOUR LIMITS

If you can't evaluate it, you're flying blind.

Remember Maria Petronoski's three gold medals? Perfectly plausible, completely made up. The further the topic is from what you know, the more carefully you have to verify, and that's exactly when AI feels most authoritative.

03 🧩 WHAT'S MISSING?

AI tells you what it knows. Not what it left out.

Look for context, exceptions, perspectives, and counterarguments the answer skipped.

04 🤖 DON'T AUTO-TRUST IT

Confident isn't the same as correct.

The smoother the answer reads, the more your guard drops. That pull is the thing to catch.

05 🔨 KEEP OWNERSHIP

You decide what to keep, change, or toss.

AI generates options. The thinking, the call, and the consequences are yours.

🔑 **AI amplifies whatever you bring to it.** Good thinking in, sharper output. Lazy thinking in, polished mediocrity. The model doesn't fix your thinking. It scales it.

There's one more level to this. Every habit on this list gets easier when you know what the machine on the other side is actually doing, because you can't be fooled by something you understand. That's exactly where this course goes next.